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ELECTION 2026

First Black Illinoisan to vote has a museum

Project XV in El Paso is built on the legacy of David Strother

By Darcel Rockett
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A web search of voting rights museums in the United States yields two locations, with one in Illinois: the Project XV Museum, roughly 90 miles southwest of Chicago in a town called El Paso.

It's built on the legacy of David Strother, the first Black man and Illinoisan to cast a vote in the U.S. after the 15th Amendment was passed in 1869, granting U.S. citizens, regardless of race, color or "previous servitude," the right to vote.

Strother was born free in Missouri in 1843 to parents who had purchased their freedom from enslavement a few years before. After his father's death, Strother, whose mother, Leah, taught him and his two siblings to read and write, settled in Illinois with them.

Before Strother became a voting pioneer, he worked on Mississippi River steamboats and cooked for the 17th Illinois Infantry during the Civil War. Afterward, he set up shop in El Paso, a rural town where the Illinois Central and Toledo, Peoria, and Western railroad lines converged.

On April 4, 1870, David Strother presented himself to the election board and, despite some pushback, cast his vote, making him among the first Black people to do so in the country. His brother Charles became the second Black man to vote in Illinois, later that same day. These historic actions are why the museum exists.

A computerized interaction of Strother on video relays his story, as he welcomes visitors to the museum with, "I hope the story of my historic vote inspires you to make your voice heard too."

"I was impressed," said Peoria mom Yolanda Lowry, She took her three children to the museum for the first time this summer after finding it on social media. The kids weren't bored, she said. "It was very developed ... put together very nicely. It was really interesting

See **MUSEUM** on Page A5



Sev Stohler, center, talks with Evynne Stitely, right, while waiting in a long line to vote on the last day of early voting at Welles Park in Chicago's Lincoln Square neighborhood on Monday. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

The stage is set

Unusually warm weather, strong early vote and federal poll monitors mark the scene as midterm Election Day arrives

By Rick Pearson and A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois' fall voting season comes to an end with Election Day on Tuesday, the final day for voters to cast a ballot after weeks of early in-person and mail voting in races from U.S. senator and governor down to county officers and judgeships.

Weatherwise, Election Day will be a "meteorological standout," said retired WGN meteorologist Tom Skilling, with unseasonably warm temperatures and a forecast high of 74 degrees. It could be the warmest Nov. 3 in nearly four decades and more akin to late September, the product of a storm system pushing southwest winds that could gust above 30 mph, he said.

Scattered rain is possible in the late morning and early afternoon, with the chances increasing as the day proceeds, he said.

"Bottom line, weather's not going to be an issue," Skilling said. "The unusual late season warmth would seem to support folks who might be impacted by inclement weather instead getting out and voting."

Polls across the state will open at 6 a.m. and close at 7 p.m. Any voter who is standing in line will be allowed to enter their polling place and cast their ballot.

Even though the polls close on Tuesday evening, local election authorities can count mailed-in ballots postmarked by 7 p.m. Tuesday that arrive within the following 14 days. The law allowing the late counts in states was upheld by the U.S. Supreme Court in June

INSIDE
Republicans and Democrats made their final pitch to voters Monday, while President Donald Trump opted to forgo the campaign trail and instead focused on his renovations at the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool. **Nation & World**

despite opposition from Republicans and President Donald Trump.

On the ballot are races for U.S. Senate, governor and other statewide offices. In addition, so are all 118 seats in the Illinois House, 39 seats in the 59-member state Senate and all 17 of Illinois' seats in the U.S. House. Locally, races for county clerk, sheriff and treasurer throughout Illinois, as well as Cook County assessor, are on the ballot, along with judicial candidates and judges seeking retention.

In Chicago, the election marks the first time that voters will elect all 21 members of the Chicago Board of Education, including its president.

On Monday, Gov. JB Pritzker, who is seeking to become the first Democrat elected governor of Illinois three times, joined Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton, the Democratic nominee for U.S. Senate, and local Democrats on a final-day barnstorming tour outside the Chicago area, visiting Collinsville, Springfield, Bloomington, Rock Island and Rockford.

Republican governor candidate Darren Bailey, a downstate farmer and former lawmaker seeking to avenge his loss to Pritzker four

See **ELECTION** on Page A5

Ex-Chicago FBI boss sues Patel, US attorney

DePodesta says he was scapegoated for failed Midway Blitz cases

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE



Special Agent in Charge of the FBI Chicago Bureau Doug DePodesta stands in his office at the FBI Chicago Division headquarters on May 29, 2025. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Four months after being forced into retirement, ex-Chicago FBI boss Douglas DePodesta is suing U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros and top officials in the Department of Justice, claiming he was scapegoated for the failed "Broadview Six" case and other controversial Operation Midway Blitz prosecutions.

The explosive 38-page lawsuit filed in U.S. District Court on Monday is virtually an unheard of turn of events for federal law enforcement in Chicago, where multiple agencies typically act in cohesion and with mutual respect.

It also brings a new level of pressure on Boutros, who has been under fire since May, when allegations of prosecutorial misconduct forced him to drop all charges alleging a group of immigration protesters impeded an agent's vehicle outside the Broadview ICE facility in September 2025.

In another extraordinary development later Monday, a federal judge ordered Boutros to testify

See **LAWSUIT** on Page A2

Dismissal in Hunter Biden case cites 'weaponization'

Judge tosses charges against ex-agents in FBI's laptop inquiry

By Eric Tucker
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — A federal judge on Monday dismissed a criminal complaint against two former FBI officials accused of lying to Congress about Hunter Biden, citing what he said was "weaponization" of President Donald Trump's Justice Department just before the midterm elections.

In a scathing, hourlong ruling read from the bench, U.S. Magistrate Judge Zia Faruqui said the investigation that produced the charges against Nikki Floris and Bradley Benavides was rushed, conducted at the behest of Trump and FBI Director Kash Patel, and dogged by "critical mistakes" that require the dismissal of the case.

"I am deeply troubled by what has happened here in this case," Faruqui said. "What has transpired here cannot be described as anything other than weaponization."

The ruling may not bring a permanent end to the matter because the Justice Department still has the option of pursuing an indictment, even though it has struggled during the Trump administration to persuade grand juries in the nation's capital to return indictments in politically charged prosecutions like this one.

In the meantime, it amounts to a resounding rebuke of a department the judge said could have sought an indictment at any time but instead opted for transparently political purposes to file a criminal complaint in the immediate run-up to Tuesday's midterm

See **BIDEN** on Page A5

Meter money for pensions

Chicago aldermen voted Monday to spend a $75 million parking meter windfall on an extra payment to Chicago's public pensions. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Florida plane crash investigation

Parts of a business jet appear to have broken off before the aircraft crashed in South Florida and erupted into a ball of flames, killing all nine on board. **Nation & World**

Rising costs of housing, food

Housing and food made up nearly half of U.S. households' spending in 2025, the most in 15 years amid rising rents, consumer costs. **Business**

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY	WED.	THU.
H:72 L: 62	H:62 L: 51	H:58 L: 46

Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A9
Arts & Living B7
Business B1
Comics B10-11
Crossword B11
Editorials A6
Horoscope B10
Nation & World B4
Television B9

179th year No. 307
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